was the market value of similar land. This value, as recorded in the Registrar's record, was quite depressed on account of agriculture being a poor value creator and real transaction prices not being disclosed in registration documents. A solatium was offered, but it was a meagre 30 per cent. For the first thirty to forty years, farmers literally received a pittance as compensation and not only became poorer but in many cases rootless. As land was usually possessed much before compensation was provided, lakhs of farmers were rendered destitute.

Lands acquired by the private sector produced enormous profits as the value of non-agricultural uses such lands were put to was much higher. Many intermediaries also saw an opportunity. Whenever there was a proposal of land acquisition, some functionaries would get wind of it, buy the land, record it at high rates and rip the cream off.

The Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, moved the pendulum to the other extreme. Compensation was made four times in rural areas and twice in urban areas. Such multiples hurt more as the base price recorded was also rigged/manipulated to be much higher than the normal market price. Further, compensation and assistance were mandated to be provided to not only landowners but various other affected persons. Provisions of social assessment and obtaining the free consent of a large number of people (70–80 per cent) in case of projects with private participation were made stringent. The process became impossible to navigate.

The result was obvious. The private sector stopped acquiring land under the 2013 Act. And the government is making payments that are way above anything justifiable.

The NDA government tried to roll back some provisions (prior consent and social impact assessment) in five specified types of acquisition: projects vital for national security or defence; rural infrastructure projects; affordable housing and housing for the poor; industrial corridors; and